



Annuscha Botes



Copyright © 2025 by
Annuscha Botes

Eclipse of Elysium. Book one of Cycles of Shadow and Light

Copyright © 2025 by Annuscha Botes

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be used or reproduced in any form whatsoever without written permission except in the case of brief quotations in critical articles or reviews.

This book is a work of fiction. Names, characters, businesses, organizations, places, events and incidents either are the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

For more information, or to book an event, contact :
annuschabotes@gmail.com

Book Title and Cover design by : Annuscha Botes

ISBN – KDP- Amazon Paperback: 9798264860799

First Edition: August 2025

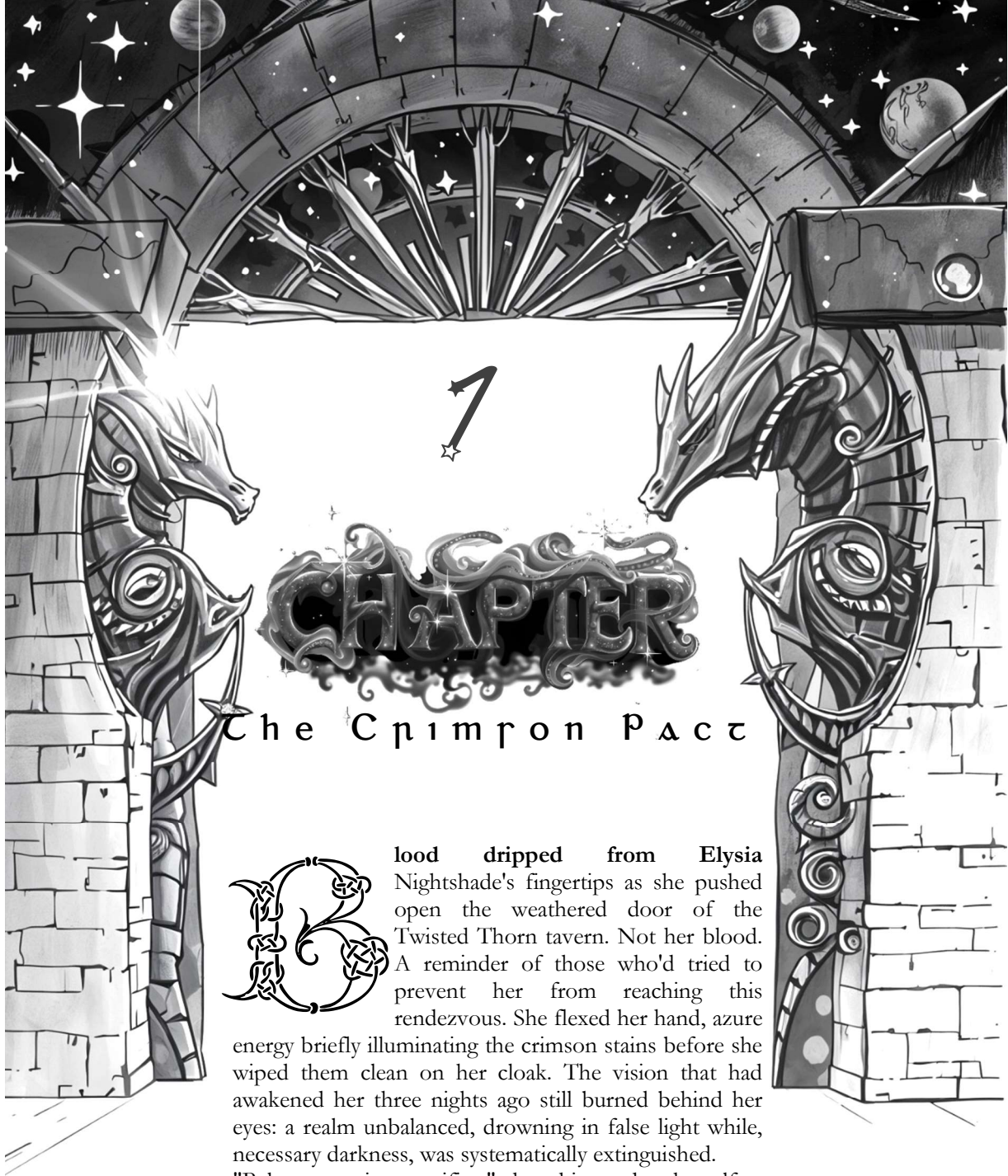
3 2 1

CHAPTERS

THE CRIMSON PACT	1
THE RAIDIAN HEART	10
THE HEART OF EBONLIGHT	18
WHEN SHADOWS AWAKEN	30
VISIONS IN THE TWILIGHT	36
WHISPERS OF THE HIDDEN ENCLAVES	41
BETWEEN FIRE AND SHADOW	46
MARKED BY FLAME, CLAIMED BY DARKNESS	57
SHADOWS OF DESIRE	68
MARKS THAT DO NOT FADE	79
THE COLD OF THE RADIANT HEART	88
WHISPERED CLAIM, SILENT CAGE	96
WHERE SHADOWS TOUCH SKIN	105
BLOODLINES IN EXILE	116
THE EDGE OF RESTRAINT	122
THE ABYSS BETWEEN US	129
BENEATH THE WINGS OF MADNESS	134
THE BEAST AND THE BLOOM	141
THORNS OF DIPLOMACY	147
A STORM BETWEEN US	158
WHAT THE BEAST FEARS	171
THE VALLEY OF DIVISION	184
IN THE SHADOW OF ABSENCE	192

ANNUSCHA BOTES

UNCHOSEN ROADS	200
BLOOD AND STARLIGHT	206
A CLAIM LEFT BLEEDING	213
THE SPACE WHERE YOU ONCE STOOD	227
WHAT THE DARKNESS MADE OF YOU	234
THE HEART'S TRUE DESIRE	244
IN THE SHADOW OF HER SMILE	257
ECHOES AND DREAMS	267
THE CODEX AND IT'S COST	276
UNBALANCED	285
TOUCHED BY A GODLESS FLAME	295
WHERE THE BEASTS BLEED	303
THE DEATH OF HOPE	316
THE WEIGHT OF TOMORROW	323
A SPELL WITHOUT MERCY	340
THE PRICE OF SALVATION	356
WHERE MAPS CANNOT GUIDE US	365
ABOUT THE AUTHOR	382
ACKNOWLEDGMENTS	384



lood dripped from Elysia Nightshade's fingertips as she pushed open the weathered door of the Twisted Thorn tavern. Not her blood. A reminder of those who'd tried to prevent her from reaching this rendezvous. She flexed her hand, azure energy briefly illuminating the crimson stains before she wiped them clean on her cloak. The vision that had awakened her three nights ago still burned behind her eyes: a realm unbalanced, drowning in false light while, necessary darkness, was systematically extinguished. "Balance requires sacrifice," she whispered to herself as patrons instinctively cleared a path before her. The Twisted Thorn enveloped her in a maelstrom of sensations. Ancient smoke-stained rafters creaked overhead like the ribcage of some primordial beast, supporting a ceiling blackened by decades of hearth fires.

SHADOWS OF ELYSIUM

The scent of burning applewood mingled with spilled honey mead and the earthier, copper-tinged scent of violence that seemed to cling to the tavern's regular clientele. Wrought-iron lanterns suspended from tarnished chains cast fickle light across the room, their flames dancing to an unheard melody, transforming the weathered tables into stages where fortunes changed hands and dangerous promises were sealed in whispers.

A hush fell as she moved through the space. Not silence, taverns like this never truly quieted, but a ripple of lowered voices, sidelong glances, bodies shifting to create distance. Her unnaturally vibrant azure hair caught the lantern light like captured lightning, but it was the subtle shimmer of arcane energy pulsing beneath her alabaster skin that caused weathered mercenaries to avert their eyes. Something ancient and predatory lurked behind her measured steps, a presence she herself didn't fully comprehend.

The dreams had grown stronger, more insistent. Visions of a shadowy figure with gleaming eyes who spoke of balance—of necessary darkness to counter oppressive light. The figure never revealed its face, but Elysia felt its presence like a phantom limb, an extension of herself she'd somehow forgotten.

"Elysium drowns in golden chains," the figure had whispered in last night's dream. "Find one who understands shadow. Only together can you restore what was broken."

The silver coin made no sound as she slid it across the bar's polished oak surface, worn smooth by countless elbows and whispered conspiracies. "Information," she said simply. Her voice was quiet as falling snow but carried the unmistakable edge of command. The voice of someone accustomed to being obeyed.

The barkeep, a mountain of a man whose face resembled granite carved by harsh weather, pocketed the coin with practiced indifference. Beneath his stoic exterior, however, the tavern-keeper's pulse quickened. Something about this slender woman with winter-pale skin and impossible blue hair sent a primitive warning through his nervous system. Predator, his instincts screamed, though he couldn't have explained why.

"What sort of information would interest you?" he asked, polishing a tankard that had seen better centuries, his knuckles white around the cloth.

Elysia's gaze slid to the shadowed corner where a notice board hung, adorned with wanted posters, job offerings, and—most prominently—three portraits rendered with unusual artistry. "The gathering," she replied, nodding toward the portraits. "Tell me about the champions."

The barkeep's expression shifted subtly, the minute rearrangement of weathered features speaking volumes. He leaned closer, his breath heavy with fermented honey and fear. "Seeking followers, they are. Or perhaps... seeking to be followed." His eyes darted nervously around the tavern before settling on specific patrons. "Each one brings a different path to power. Each one dangerous in their way. But mind yourself; he hesitated, the warning catching in his throat.

"What?" Elysia pressed, her eyes narrowing.

"They say the Golden Order has spies everywhere these days," he whispered. "Anyone gathering strength is considered a threat to their 'perfect realm.'"

Elysia's lips curved into a cold smile. "Perfect for whom, I wonder?"

She turned from the bar, feeling the weight of unseen eyes tracking her movement. The Golden Order. Self-proclaimed bringers of light and prosperity, had ruled Elysium for three generations, their gilded temples rising higher as the shadows beneath them deepened. Peace through subjugation. Prosperity for the few. Light that blinded rather than illuminated.

The three portraits dominated the weathered wood of the notice board, each face gazing back with such intensity that they appeared more window than artwork, offering glimpses into souls of extraordinary power. Each portrait bore a name and title in elegant script, alongside a symbol that pulsed with subtle magic, a means for interested parties to signal their desire for audience.

She approached with measured steps, studying each in turn. Rafahell Darkin, the Dragonborn Sorcerer, whose scales gleamed like burnished cobalt even in mere ink. Xironia Ambrozia, the Harpy, whose predatory eyes clutched secrets like jealously guarded treasures. And finally, Cain Birsha, the Beastman Shapeshifter, whose gaze smoldered with barely contained savagery that threatened to leap from parchment to flesh.

A flicker of recognition sparked within her at the sight of the beastman's image—not memory, precisely, but the same resonance she felt during her visions. *This one understands shadow*, something whispered from the depths of her consciousness.

The harpy's portrait symbol pulsed softly as Elysia's gaze lingered upon it. From the corner of her eye, she noticed an answering flash from a shadowed table near the hearth where Xironia herself sat, observing the tavern through predatory eyes. As Elysia approached, the harpy's keen gaze locked onto her, equal parts hunter and appraiser.

"I was wondering when someone interesting would walk through those doors," Xironia purred, her voice musical yet discordant, a beautiful instrument slightly out of tune. She extended a winged hand in greeting, feathers gleaming iridescent in the firelight. "Most who seek my services lack... imagination."

The harpy's beauty was undeniable; exotic features framed by feathers that shifted between copper and gold in the tavern's flickering light. But beneath that beauty lurked calculation so cold it bordered on cruelty. Elysia had seen that look before, in the eyes of marketplace vendors who sold watered wine at premium prices, in the smiles of Golden Order clerics who preached charity while wearing gemstone rings.

"Please," Xironia gestured to the empty chair at her table with a taloned hand. The movement revealed a flash of silver beneath her feathers—a dagger, expertly concealed. "Join me."

Elysia settled into the chair, taking a moment to order her thoughts. The coppery scent of blood still clung to Xironia's feathers beneath layers of exotic perfume, evidence of recent violence the harpy hadn't bothered to fully cleanse. "I seek a companion in a quest for truth," she said finally, meeting the harpy's unnervingly intelligent eyes.

Xironia reclined, a sly smile playing across her beaked features. "Ah, truth." She toyed with a silver goblet, talons tapping a rhythm against the metal. "Such a malleable concept, wouldn't you agree? One person's truth is another's deception." The harpy

SHADOWS OF ELYSIUM

leaned forward suddenly, her eyes gleaming with predatory interest. "But let's not pretend. Your aura speaks of power, of ambition. What is it you *truly* seek, blue-hair?"

"I need allies who understand that sometimes light casts the deepest shadows," Elysia replied, deliberately vague. "What talents would you bring to such a cause?"

The harpy's eyes sparkled with mischief as she leaned forward, her voice dropping to a conspiratorial whisper. "My skills as a thief and manipulator are second to none. I move silent as thought, pick locks that would defy masters, and my silver tongue—" she smiled, revealing teeth too sharp for comfort, "—can charm even the most wary souls."

To demonstrate, Xironia flicked her wrist. A golden medallion; the barkeep's prize possession that had hung around his neck moments before, dangled from her talons. "With my cunning, we could gather intelligence, secure resources, outmaneuver any obstacle." Her feathers rustled with barely contained excitement. "Together, we could dance through shadows unseen."

As the harpy spoke, a tendril of azure energy—invisible to all but Elysia—slithered from beneath the table, winding around the harpy's ankle. The energy probe confirmed what Elysia's instincts had already suggested: Xironia's aura pulsed with deception and self-interest. Whatever alliance they might forge would last only until the harpy found greater advantage elsewhere.

More troubling, beneath Xironia's outer aura lurked a familiar golden shimmer, the telltale signature of the Golden Order's magic. This thief didn't merely steal objects; she collected information for the very regime Elysia sought to challenge.

"Unfortunately," she said, rising with fluid grace while severing the energy connection, "I don't feel we would be compatible companions."

Xironia's expression transformed from confidence to indignation in an instant. A sharp, avian cry of displeasure escaped her as Elysia departed. "Your loss," the harpy called after her, the musical quality gone from her voice, replaced by brittle anger. "Few receive my offer twice!"

As Elysia moved away, she caught sight of Xironia slipping a small golden medallion from her feathers—not the barkeep's token, but something far more significant: the emblem of the Golden Order's intelligence branch. The harpy pressed it against the underside of the table, whispering something that caused the medallion to pulse with light.

One enemy revealed, Elysia thought grimly. How many more hide in plain sight?

Her gaze drifted next to Rafahell Darkin, the Dragonborn sorcerer seated alone at a corner table. Unlike the performative presence of the harpy, Rafahell projected studied concentration, his scaled hands delicately turning the pages of an ancient tome bound in leather so dark it seemed to absorb the tavern's meager light.

As Elysia approached, he looked up, eyes the color of ancient amber meeting hers. The pages of his book briefly glowed with necromantic symbols before he closed it with a snap. Wordlessly, he gestured to the chair opposite him.

"You have questions," he stated rather than asked, his voice carrying the dry, papery quality of one who speaks more to books than people. "About power. About

knowledge long buried." He tilted his head, studying her with scholarly interest. "Your aura has a... unique resonance. Old magic. Very old."

A chill ran down Elysia's spine. Few could see auras, fewer still could read them with such precision. "And what does that tell you about me?" she asked, sliding into the seat across from him.

The Dragonborn's scales shifted slightly, catching the light like faceted gemstones. "That you contain multitudes," he replied cryptically. "That perhaps we share certain... academic interests."

When she offered no immediate response, Rafahell filled the silence. "I seek to uncover hidden secrets and harness arcane power," he said, running one clawed finger along the spine of his book. "As a Dragonborn sorcerer, I possess the innate magic of my draconic heritage. I can manipulate shadow and necromantic magic, summon darkness to obscure our movements, and unearth knowledge long buried."

His clawed fingers traced arcane symbols in the air between them, leaving momentary trails of purple light. The symbols made Elysia's vision blur, her head throb with sudden pain—not from any attack, but from something deep within responding to his magic.

"My research into forbidden knowledge allows me to access spells that amplify powers beyond conventional limits," he continued, oblivious to her discomfort. "With my abilities, we could harness the arcane to reshape reality itself."

As he spoke, the atmosphere around their table grew colder, the shadows deeper. Something ancient and hungry stirred in the depths of his amber eyes, something that had nothing to do with balancing light and darkness and everything to do with consuming both.

"And what would you seek in return for such... assistance?" Elysia asked, fighting the urge to recoil as tendrils of necromantic energy probed at her mental defenses.

Rafahell smiled, revealing teeth too sharp and numerous for his reptilian mouth. "A patron with vision. Someone who understands that knowledge is never forbidden, merely... misunderstood." His voice dropped lower. "And perhaps... a small sample of your rather unique essence. For academic purposes, of course."

Without speaking, Elysia stood, her aura manifesting in subtle waves that quieted the ambient noise around them. Rafahell's expression shifted from confidence to uncertainty as his own magical presence seemed to diminish in her proximity.

"I think not," she said simply.

The Dragonborn's eyes narrowed, calculation replacing scholarly interest. "You seek power but reject its price," he observed. "Curious." He retrieved his book, running one scaled finger possessively along its binding. "When you discover that half-measures achieve nothing, you may reconsider my offer."

"There are prices too steep for any gain," Elysia replied, turning away. As she did, she caught a glimpse of the book's title, momentarily visible as Rafahell shifted it: *Communion with the Void*. Another dead end, and possibly another threat.

The encounter left a sour taste in her mouth. Two champions approached, two rejected. Her vision had promised a worthy ally, yet she'd found only deception and

SHADOWS OF ELYSIUM

hunger thus far. Perhaps the dreams had been nothing more than that. Meaningless phantasms born of desperation.

She had nearly reached the tavern door when the atmosphere shifted. Conversations faltered mid-sentence. The clatter of tankards ceased. Even the crackling of the hearth fire seemed to dim as a palpable pressure descended upon the room.

"They say you seek the darkness in times of light."

The voice resonated from behind her, deep and rumbling like distant thunder rolling across mountain peaks. Elysia didn't startle—she'd sensed his approach, felt the subtle shift in the tavern's atmosphere as patrons instinctively created distance.

Her hand, which had been reaching for the tavern door, fell to her side. She turned, finding herself face to chest with the massive figure from the third portrait. In person, Cain Birsha commanded even more presence than art could capture.

Standing nearly seven feet tall, his powerful frame rippled with muscle beneath midnight-black fur that seemed to consume the tavern's meager illumination. Arcane tribal markings adorned his arms, pulsing with subdued power, while bones of unknown origin served as ornaments across his broad chest.

He had watched her from the moment she stepped through the door. Not because she was beautiful,—though she was, in a way that made his instincts snarl—but because the shadows clung to her. Whispered to her. Responded to her.

Cain Birsha had known darkness. Had become it, once. But this girl, this blue-haired phantom with eyes like storm glass, was different. She wore the darkness like a second skin.

Now, she stood before him. Smaller than he expected. But the power in her... it tugged at the primal thing caged inside his ribs.

Their eyes met.

And the beast in him—the one he'd tamed but never silenced—leaned forward and whispered: *Mine*.

It was his eyes that transfixed her, crimson pools that burned with inner fire, at once savage and calculating.

Those eyes held hers without flinching, without the calculation of the harpy or the hunger of the Dragonborn. Instead, they burned with something far more dangerous: recognition.

"And if I am?" she replied, voice steady despite the hammering of her heart.

Cain's mouth curved into what might have been interpreted as a smile, revealing teeth designed for rending flesh. "Then perhaps our paths align." He gestured with a massive clawed hand toward an empty table nestled in the tavern's darkest corner. "Let's discuss what you seek... and what I offer."

Something stirred in the recesses of Elysia's mind, a fragment of her recurring dream where a shadowed figure extended its hand through impenetrable darkness. *This one*, the voice from her visions whispered, suddenly crystal clear. *This one understands*.

She nodded once, and they moved through the tavern together. The crowd parted before Cain like a sea before a leviathan, conversations faltering as they passed. Fear perfumed the air, almost palpable.

Yet beneath that fear, Elysia sensed something else, a current of respect mingled with wary admiration. Unlike the Dragonborn's cold arrogance or the harpy's slippery charm, Cain's power was honest in its savagery. He made no pretense of being anything other than what he was: a predator among predators.

The table occupied a shadowed recess far from prying eyes and eager ears. Cain settled his immense frame onto a bench that groaned in protest, while Elysia took the seat opposite. Between them sat a single guttering candle, its wavering flame creating a dance of light and shadow across their faces, emphasizing the sharp contrast between her delicate features and his bestial countenance.

"You're not what I expected," Cain said, his voice modulated to a softer register that nonetheless vibrated with power.

"And what did you expect?" Elysia asked, resting her slender hands upon the scarred wooden tabletop.

"Someone who would flinch," he replied, studying her with newfound interest. "Someone who would approach with flowery words about destiny and purpose, trying to manipulate me into service." His crimson eyes reflected the candle flame, twin fires burning in the darkness. "Instead, you face me directly. Rare, for your kind."

"My kind?" she asked, one eyebrow lifting slightly.

"Humans," he clarified, the word carrying the weight of history—much of it bloody. "Especially those who wield power as you clearly do."

"Perhaps I'm not as human as I appear," Elysia said, surprising herself with the words that seemed to rise unbidden from some deeper part of her consciousness.

Something shifted in Cain's expression, a flicker of recognition, perhaps even respect, transforming his monstrous features momentarily into something approaching understanding. "Perhaps none of us are what we appear," he conceded, leaning back slightly. "Which brings us to the matter at hand. You seek a traveling partner. One who will help accomplish... what, exactly?"

Elysia considered her words with the care of one selecting weapons before battle. The truth was that she sought not just any warrior but one whose strength could match the trials ahead. Someone unbound by conventional morality, who could embrace the shadows as readily as she must.

"I need someone who won't hesitate when blood must be spilled," she said finally, her voice barely above a whisper yet crystal clear. "Someone who understands that sometimes darkness is necessary to restore balance."

"Balance," he repeated, the word sounding foreign on his tongue, as though testing an unfamiliar weapon. "An unusual concern for one who deals in shadows."

"Light and dark, Cain Birsha," Elysia replied, leaning slightly closer. "Neither can exist without the other. Elysium has forgotten this truth, bathing itself in golden light while ignoring the rot and suffering festering beneath. The so-called Golden Age is built on bones and tears."

As she spoke, the candle between them flared inexplicably higher, illuminating the savage planes of his face—the scars that spoke of countless battles, the barely restrained power in the set of his jaw. For a moment, Elysia thought she saw something ancient

SHADOWS OF ELYSIUM

and knowing pass behind his eyes, as though her words had awakened some dormant memory.

"The Golden Order hunts those who question their perfect realm," she continued, voice dropping lower. "They call it peace, but it's subjugation dressed in pretty words. Their 'light' blinds the masses to the chains they forge."

Cain studied her for a long moment, his massive clawed hands splayed flat against the wooden table like twin spiders. When he spoke again, his voice carried a new weight, as though choosing words with uncharacteristic care.

"The Order destroyed my clan," he said finally, the admission clearly costing him. "While I was hunting, they came with their gilded armor and righteous proclamations. Called us abominations, mongrels who tainted their perfect bloodlines." His claws dug into the wooden table, leaving deep furrows. "I returned to find nothing but ashes and bodies. And one survivor who died in my arms, telling me they'd taken a prisoner—someone important to me."

The raw pain in his voice resonated with something deep within Elysia; an echo of loss she couldn't quite place but felt with bone-deep certainty.

"They took someone from you," she said softly. Not a question.

Cain's eyes flashed dangerously. "Shade Crimson. We were... pack-mates from childhood. They took her for their 'research'—their endless quest to understand and control what they fear." His massive form seemed to ripple slightly, the first hint of his shapeshifting abilities responding to his emotional state. "I've been hunting them ever since, gathering strength, building my horde. Waiting for the moment to strike."

"And now?" Elysia asked.

"Now I find myself across from a blue-haired stranger who speaks of balance and necessary darkness." His eyes held hers, searching for deception or manipulation. "You should know what you're asking for, little mage. I am not a hero from children's tales. I have led raids that left villages in ashes. I have feasted on the flesh of my enemies and decorated my dwelling with their bones." His voice dropped lower, a rumble that seemed to vibrate through the table between them. "The darkness you seek may be more than you bargained for."

"I don't seek a hero," Elysia replied, her voice calm as still water. "I seek a force of nature."

A slow smile spread across Cain's bestial features, revealing teeth that could rend flesh from bone with terrifying efficiency. "Then perhaps we are well-matched, after all." He extended a massive clawed hand across the table, the gesture both offering and challenge. "I accept your proposition, Elysia Nightshade. Let us bring this balance you speak of, through fire and blood if necessary."

As their hands clasped—her slender fingers nearly disappearing in his massive grip—a strange energy pulsed between them. Outside, thunder rolled across a previously clear sky, as though the world itself acknowledged their pact with trepidation.

In that moment of connection, a fragment of vision flashed behind Elysia's eyes. Her and Cain, blood-soaked, standing atop a shattered palace of gold. Behind them, the dawn rose not in gold but indigo. Dark. Honest.

She withdrew her hand, a slight smile playing across her features. "We begin tomorrow. The Black Market of Uranium houses weapons and artifacts we'll need for what lies ahead."

Cain nodded, his crimson eyes gleaming with anticipation. "A fitting first step. The underground has always been more honest than the shining spires above." His massive hand moved to the amulet around his neck, a dark, twisted totem that seemed to absorb rather than reflect the candle's light. "This journey will change us both, I think."

"All journeys of consequence do," Elysia replied softly.



As they parted ways for the night, Elysia felt a strange certainty settle over her like a mantle. Of all the paths that had stretched before her, she had chosen perhaps the most dangerous, but also the most direct. The vision that had haunted her dreams for months—the shadowy figure with glowing eyes who whispered of balance restored—no longer seemed mere fantasy.

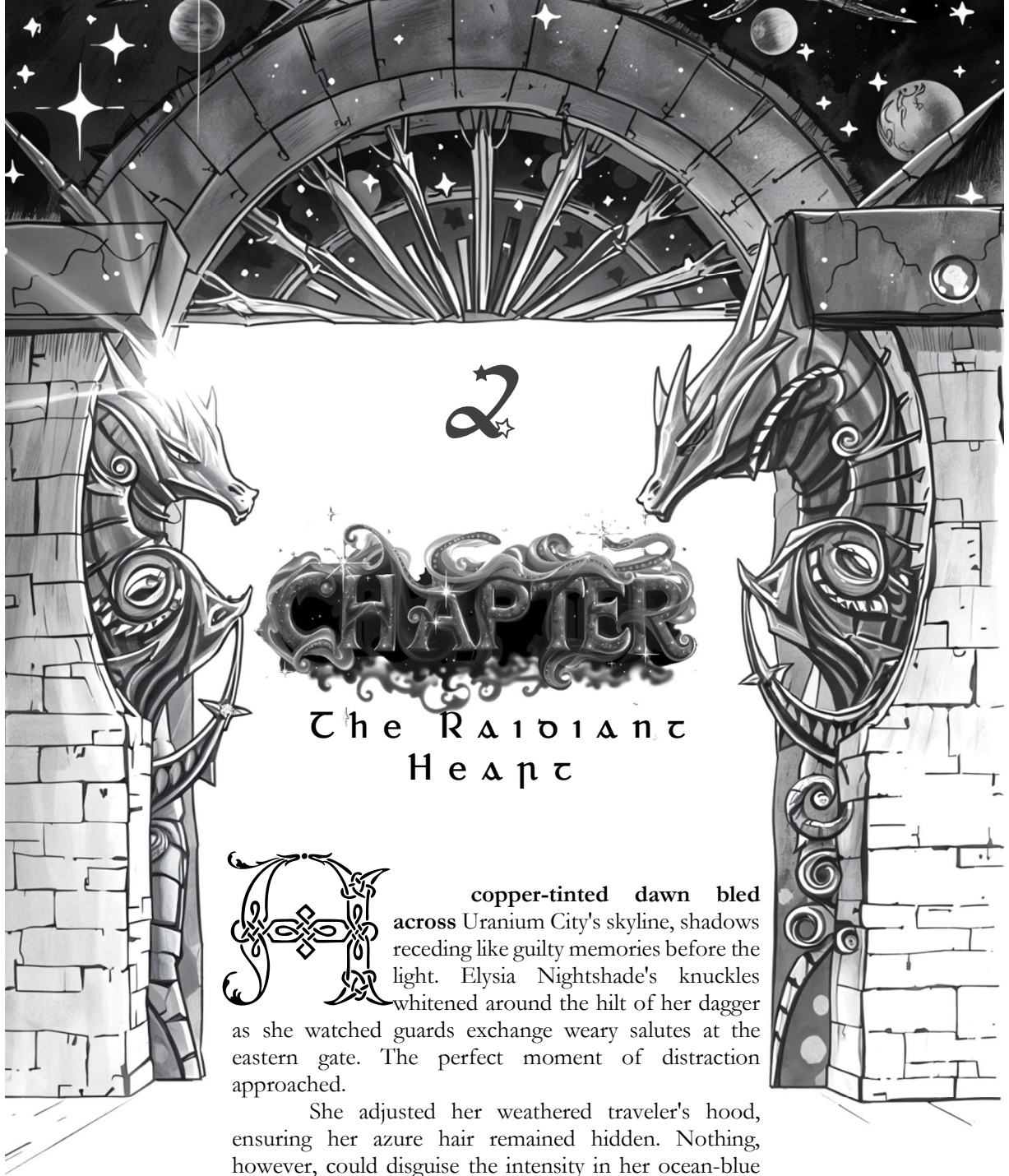
She returned to her rented room, closing the door behind her. In the privacy of these four walls, she whispered to the empty room, a question without expectation of answer. "What am I?"

For a heartbeat, her reflection in the small looking glass above the washbasin shifted, revealing not the blue-haired traveler but a figure wreathed in shadows, eyes gleaming with ancient purpose. Then it was gone, so quickly she might have imagined it.

Yet the sensation lingered, a feeling of coming home to a place she'd never been, of remembering things she'd never experienced. "Heal the realm," she murmured, recalling the vision that had set her on this path. But healing sometimes required cutting away infected flesh, lancing festering wounds before they could be mended.

Elysia laid down on the bed, not bothering to remove her travel clothes. Sleep would be necessary for what was to come. As consciousness faded, one thought remained: The realm of Elysium, with its false golden age and buried truths, would soon feel the tremors of change.

And she, though none yet knew it—not even herself—would be at the center of the storm.



F copper-tinted dawn bled across Uranium City's skyline, shadows receding like guilty memories before the light. Elysia Nightshade's knuckles whitened around the hilt of her dagger as she watched guards exchange weary salutes at the eastern gate. The perfect moment of distraction approached.

She adjusted her weathered traveler's hood, ensuring her azure hair remained hidden. Nothing, however, could disguise the intensity in her ocean-blue eyes—eyes that had seen too much during her years at the Golden Age Order, where they'd tried to mold her into a vessel of pure light magic while suppressing the darkness that had always whispered inside her.